

IOOS REAUTHORIZATION BRIEF

America's Ocean Intelligence System

The case for reauthorizing the Integrated Ocean Observing System (IOOS)

Prepared for: Congressional Staff

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5x Return on investment	\$400B U.S. ocean economy enabled	325K Ocean Enterprise jobs supported	\$280M Requested over 5 years
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Bottom line: IOOS is proven national infrastructure. It turns ocean observations into safer ports, better storm decisions, stronger coastal economies, and private-sector growth.

WHAT IOOS IS

IOOS is the United States' national network of ocean sensors, buoys, radar systems, satellites, and data platforms that continuously monitors U.S. coastal waters, the Great Lakes, and ocean conditions.

Think of it as the **interstate highway system for ocean data**: a federal investment that enables private-sector activity, operational decisions, and public safety outcomes that would not be possible without shared data infrastructure.

WHY IT MATTERS: THREE THINGS ONLY IOOS CAN DO

1. Disaster Response

Storm surge kills more Americans than any other hurricane hazard. IOOS real-time coastal data powers forecasts that determine evacuation timing.

Template example: During Hurricane Sandy, IOOS data enabled 80 ships to safely evacuate Hampton Roads three days early, avoiding an estimated \$28M in potential losses.

2. Port Efficiency

IOOS water-level and current data helps port pilots optimize vessel drafts, reduce delays, and minimize costly lightering operations.

Matrix evidence: Tampa Bay PORTS(R) benefits are Estimated \$2.4M-\$4.8M in high-confidence direct annual benefits and \$4.4M-\$7.0M in presently realized quantifiable annual benefit.

3. Coastal Communities

IOOS powers HAB early-warning systems, supports fisheries decisions, and feeds search-and-rescue operations on every U.S. coastline.

Matrix evidence: HAB forecasts help managers focus testing and guide closure/advisory decisions. HF radar surface-current data support USCG search planning through SAROPS.

THE ECONOMY IOOS ENABLES

IOOS is public data infrastructure for the ocean economy, including commercial shipping, offshore energy, recreational boating, coastal tourism, and seafood.

The Ocean Enterprise survey reported **2020 survey identified 814 businesses about 325000 employees and estimated \$8B Ocean Enterprise revenue; 22% of revenue from exports**. Use this as sector context, not a claim that IOOS directly caused all revenue or jobs.

Commercial shipping and port operations	Offshore energy development
Recreational boating and coastal tourism	Commercial and recreational fisheries
Coastal hazard and emergency management	U.S. Navy and Coast Guard operations
Marine technology industry	Shellfish and aquaculture businesses

THE LEGISLATIVE MOMENT

H.R. 2294 passed the House in March 2026 and companion S. 2126 is pending Senate action. Both bills authorize **\$280 million over FY2026-2030**, or \$56 million per year, consistent with current appropriations.

This is not a new program. It is routine reauthorization of proven national infrastructure with documented economic and public safety value.

STAFF TAKEAWAY

Do not make this complicated: IOOS is a modest federal investment that coastal states, ports, emergency managers, scientists, and ocean businesses already rely on. The policy choice is whether to keep that infrastructure stable.

THE ASK

Support Senate floor action on S. 2126 | Defend IOOS funding in CJS appropriations at or above current levels | Request a district-specific briefing on how IOOS serves coastal, port, fisheries, or emergency management stakeholders.

Source note: Built from the supplied Word brief template plus the current evidence matrix and source registry. Template legislative and non-matrix figures should be source-checked before external distribution.